

| By Subhash Mishra |

With general elections approaching, the temptation among political parties to brag about development is quite strong. The Congress has already launched its campaign harping on the theme, and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati is not one to fall behind. In a virtual media blitzkrieg during the last month, she has announced new projects and schemes to the tune of over Rs 5,000 crore and launched populist schemes for the girl child.

The latest development push is aimed at dispelling the impression that the BSP Government is merely serving the interests of Dalits and squandering hundreds of crores of rupees to build monuments and memorials in the name of Dalit icons. Mayawati has already come under attack from the Samajwadi Party which, referring to her fetish for such memorials, labelled her "patharon ki devi (goddess of stones)". To which her retort is that she is creating history since no government in the past has done so much for Dalit heroes and nor would any government in future. Her sworn enemy, former chief minister Mulayam Singh Yadav, may be threatening to demolish those statues, but even he would not dare to do so lest there be a backlash and violent uprising against him.

For the moment, to avoid being seen as chief minister of one section—the Scheduled Castes (scs) and catering to their interests only—Mayawati, on the eve of the forthcoming Lok Sabha elections, is wooing non-Dalits equally. To solicit the Brahmin-led upper castes, she is set to pour funds into the development of religious cities like Mathura, Varanasi and Faizabad (Ayodhya) where Hindu devotees flock on many occasions round the year.

At present Mayawati is working on her two-pronged strategy of a balancing act between the "Bahujan Samaj"

स्थान: लखनऊ

दिनांक: 4 फरवरी 2009



Getting Down to BUSINESS

With elections coming up and opponents berating her obsession with monuments and memorials, BSP leader Mayawati has begun to brandish the development card

and "Sarvajan" (all people). For her core constituency, the scs, she is addressing their sentiments and emotions by building monuments and memorials to commemorate B.R. Ambedkar and Kanshi Ram, as well as empowering them socially and economically. Mayawati has ordered waivers for scs who availed loans for self-employment from the Uttar Pradesh Scheduled Caste Development Corporation; land allotments for urban slum-dwellers; cash assistance and bicycles under the

Savitri Bai Phule Balika Shiksha Madad Yojana and other similar schemes. She is confident that the last 22 months of her running the state won't mean the bahujan samaj will ditch her in the general elections.

Cherishing her dream of creating history by becoming the first Scheduled Caste prime minister, she is equally concerned about retaining the Brahmin-led upper castes who voted for her en masse in the Assembly elections 2007 and ensured an absolute majority for the BSP, the

AFTER SPENDING OVER Rs 2,000 CRORE ON IDOLISING DALIT ICONS, MAYAWATI IS FOCUSING